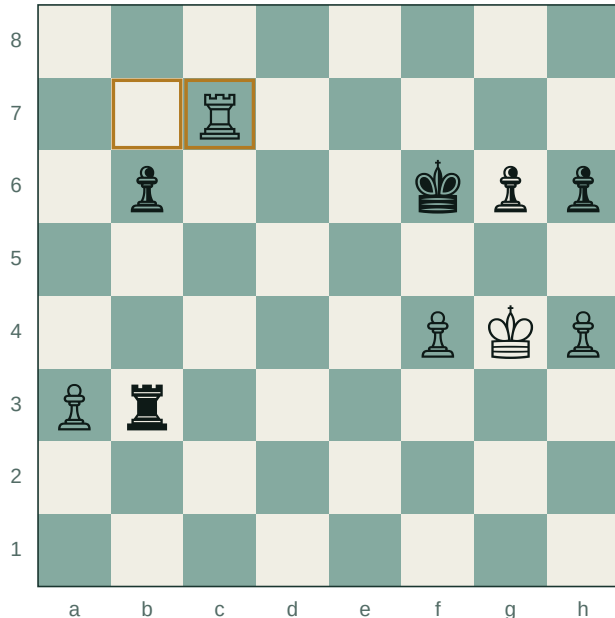


Rook-ending tactics: Black, move 39

Rook-ending tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 39.Rc7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...h5#

39...h5# Mate: pawn on h5 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on g4. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Pawn on h5. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A routine rook placement can miss a skewer or promotion with check. Let concrete tactics override a guideline when they conflict.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Rook endings combine pawn races with checks, cutoffs, and promotion tactics. Activity is vital, but the exact move order often decides whether a pawn can advance safely.

HOW TO LOOK

Check the kings' exposure, the rooks' checking distance, and the passed pawns. Calculate forcing checks before applying a general rook-ending rule.

The defending king is on g4. Geometrically undefended: rook on c7. Check for tactical protection.